Dicey Dungeons — Design Breakdown

Gameplay, level design, animation and art style

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Overview

Dicey Dungeons is a roguelike deck-builder by Irish designer Terry Cavanagh, released 13 August 2019 on Windows, macOS, Linux and Nintendo Switch, and ported later to Xbox (December 2020), iOS and Android (November 2021) and PlayStation 4/5 (July 2022 and February 2023).

Role	Person
Design and code	Terry Cavanagh (*VVVVVV*, *Super Hexagon*)
Art and animation	Marlowe Dobbe
Music and SFX	Chipzel (Niamh Houston)
Writing	Holly Gramazio
Additional programming	Justo Delgado Baudí
Modding support	Lars Doucet

It began as a 7 Day Roguelike jam entry in 2018. Cavanagh had recently got back into *Dream Quest* and wanted to make his own deckbuilder; using dice was, in his words, a dumb idea to take that premise somewhere new. It turned out to have far more depth than he expected, and he spent the next eighteen months building it out in public through fortnightly alpha releases on itch.io. Built in Haxe, using OpenFL and Starling.

The frame story: Lady Luck, goddess of fortune, has turned six contestants into walking six-sided dice and entered them into her game show. Reach the bottom of the dungeon and she grants your heart's desire.

Core mechanics

The central move is an inversion of RPG combat: instead of making a move and waiting to see what the RNG does, you get the RNG up front and decide how to make the best of it.

Combat is one-on-one and turn-based. Each turn you roll a handful of d6s and drag them onto equipment cards. Each card has slots with conditions — any die, odd only, even only, exactly a 4, 3 or higher. A basic sword takes any die and deals that much damage: 2 on a 2, 6 on a 6. From there it complicates: cards that split a die in two, cards with countdowns or limited reuses, cards that accept only one specific value but pay off hugely. Enemies use the same system with their own visible equipment, so you can read exactly what they are capable of before committing.

Three structural choices do most of the work.

Static layouts, not draws. Cavanagh found that random card draws plus random dice rolls made the game feel far too chaotic. Equipment layouts are therefore fixed and changed only between battles, with one deliberate exception — the Jester, who exists to explore that variation. You manage a backpack outside combat and choose what to bring in.

Statuses attack your rolls, not your health. Most status effects interfere with dice rather than dealing damage, which keeps every debuff a puzzle rather than a subtraction.

Status	Effect
Frozen	Turns the highest die rolled into a 1
Burn	Sets the next die on fire; 2 HP to extinguish
Shocked	Disables random equipment; spend a die to clear
Weaken	Makes a random piece of equipment less powerful
Blind	Hides the dice values
Poison	Lose health each turn; pierces shields
Fury	The next equipment used fires twice
Silence	Blocks character skills and Limit Breaks

Limit Breaks. Each class has a signature move charged by taking damage — so levelling up and raising max HP actually raises the amount you must lose to trigger it. You can also charge it deliberately by clicking burning dice at 2 HP each. Effects range from extra dice to repeating an action to heavy direct damage.

The six classes

Each class is a different answer to one design question: how do you introduce uncertainty into each run so that turn-to-turn plays stay interesting? The Warrior rerolls, the Thief splits and steals, the Robot gambles.

Class	Uncertainty mechanic	Limit Break
Warrior	Reroll a die up to three times	Fury — double the next action
Thief	Lockpick splits dice randomly; borrows a random enemy item each turn	Unlucky Roll — four extra 1s
Robot	No dice at all; a CPU meter you push for more, busting if you overshoot	Autoroll — guaranteed jackpot
Inventor	Must destroy one equipped item after each battle to build a free gadget	Focus — all dice become 6
Witch	Spend dice to summon spells into slots, then more dice to cast them	Crystal Ball — three extra dice
Jester	The true deck-builder: equipment is drawn as cards	Varies by build

Most characters start at 24 HP, gain 4 per level, and begin with 2 dice, picking up a third and fourth at levels 2, 4 and 6. The Witch starts with 3 dice instead; the Robot trades dice for CPU; the Jester gains no extra dice on level up, which is why a lean deck matters so much for that class.

Level design

Run structure. Six floors per run, each a short branching node graph rather than an explorable space. Floor sizes follow a standard curve, with per-episode exceptions.

Floor	Size
1	Tiny
2	Small
3	Normal
4	Normal
5	Big
6	Boss floor

Node types. Enemies that block passage, apples for healing, anvils to upgrade equipment, shops to buy and sell, a trading post to swap gear, chests for new equipment, and doors to the next floor. You can take as long as you like before a fight — reorganising the backpack, visiting other nodes first. No timer, no fog of war. The floor is a resource-allocation puzzle laid out in the open.

Hand-authored loot tables. This is the least visible and most important part of the level design. Every episode specifies exactly which items appear in which chests on which floors, what each shop stocks, and what the level-3 and level-5 rewards are. The Warrior's opening episode excludes rare enemies and the boss Drake entirely — he would be too complicated as a first boss. Difficulty is tuned through curation, not just numbers.

Episodes are the real level design. Winning unlocks new characters and new episodes with rulesets that rewrite the game rather than scaling it. Each character has roughly six, with a final Backstage episode unlocked only after all six Bonus Rounds are cleared.

- *Curse of Greed* (Warrior) — start with two upgraded battle axes and upgrade everything you find, but take a curse at the start of every turn
- *Parallel Universe* (all characters) — every status effect changes meaning: Frozen reduces all dice by 1 rather than flattening the highest, Burn lets you use burning dice but disables that card for two turns, Poison infects a piece of equipment
- *The Elimination Round*, *Bonus Round*, and the later Halloween Special and Reunion DLC episodes extend the same idea

The effect is that the "levels" players actually remember are rule sets, not maps. The maps are deliberately thin so the rules can carry the variety.

Art style

Marlowe Dobbe handled essentially all of the art direction. She describes the style as emblematic of her own work as an artist, and notes it felt like a fresh fit precisely because it is not a style you would associate with a roguelike.

Visual vocabulary. Bright flat colours and bold shapes, rooted in mid-century illustration, mixed with print illustration, anime and modern character design. Mary Blair, the Disney designer, appeared on her mood boards as a starting point for the visual direction. Cavanagh also sees a little *Chrono Trigger* in some designs, especially the Inventor.

The enemy redesign. Cavanagh had made all the art himself and the enemies were generically *Dungeons & Dragons*–themed; he wanted away from that. Dobbe reskinned each one based on its existing move set — turning a health-sucking vampire bat into a vacuum cleaner that also sucks health. The result is a wildly varied, *Alice in Wonderland* type of world where you might fight a vampire, or a vacuum, or a space marine, or a thief with sticky hands who steals your money. Mechanics first, fiction fitted afterwards.

The D6 problem. All six protagonists share the same base body — a six-sided die. The design work went into finding visual archetypes, facial features, outfits and colours distinct enough to tell them apart despite that shared silhouette.

The game show frame. Cavanagh wanted something different from the dark, serious tone common to roguelikes. Chipzel suggested the game show setting, which supplied the stakes, the antagonist and the characters' motivations while keeping everything light. She had been reminded of 1990s game shows every time she played — the luck of the draw, the cute visuals, the ruthlessness under the cheese.

Animation and presentation

Tooling. Dobbe worked in Adobe Photoshop and After Effects. That points to rig-and-transform animation over hand-drawn parts rather than full frame-by-frame work, which suits the flat-shape style and keeps the workload manageable across dozens of enemies.

What it does functionally. Every combatant idles with a constant bounce and squash-and-stretch wobble. This matters in a game where you may sit staring at a static combat screen for minutes deciding on a placement — reviewers writing about the demo singled out the animated life in the characters. Dice have physical roll and snap animations, hit reactions punch and recoil, and status icons pulse. All of it reinforces feedback in an interface that is otherwise a spreadsheet of numbered slots.

Audio. Chipzel wrote all the music in LSDJ on a Nintendo Game Boy, and made most sound effects on a Eurorack system and assorted synthesisers. She treated the game show theme as licence for an audio overload, on the grounds that game shows are hectic.

Why the pieces fit

Randomness is shown to you before you commit rather than after, so a bad roll becomes a puzzle instead of a punishment.

The level design removes every other source of pressure to protect that. No timers, no hidden information, fully readable enemies, unlimited planning time — the only tension left is the dice. Variety that other roguelikes get from map generation comes instead from episode rulesets, which is cheaper to author and easier to balance.

The art and animation work against the genre's default grimness on purpose. A run that is fundamentally arithmetic feels like a bright, silly game show rather than a spreadsheet, and the constant idle motion keeps a static screen alive while the player thinks.

Sources

- Road to the IGF: Cavanagh, Houston & Dobbe's Dicey Dungeons — Game Developer, March 2019. The primary source for design intent, art direction, tooling and the game show frame.
- Marlowe Dobbe on the Art of Dicey Dungeons — Cliqist, July 2019. The enemy redesign process.
- Interview with Dicey Dungeons' Terry Cavanagh — The Avocado, December 2020. Mary Blair and *Chrono Trigger* influences.
- Official Dicey Dungeons Wiki — floor sizes, episode lists, status tables, per-episode loot tables.
- Dicey Dungeons Wiki (Fandom) — node types, status effects, enemy rosters by floor.
- Wikipedia — credits, release and port dates.
- Interview: Marlowe Dobbe, Art Director of Floppy Knights — Hey Poor Player, February 2021. Mid-century illustration influence.

Class stats (HP, dice progression, Limit Breaks) come from community guides rather than official documentation and are approximate.